These are example questions from our team's interview process for early- to mid-career candidates. This is how *we* do it, not how *every* team does it. Our process is intentionally thorough, often involving 4–6 interviews per candidate with different teammates to get a holistic view. We look beyond design skills to understand how someone collaborates, learns, approaches problems, and shows up as a teammate.

This list is meant to give you insight into the kinds of things we care about and like to talk about with a candidate—not to serve as a checklist or official IBM document. Every interview is different, and these questions are just suggestions. Use them as a reference, a learning tool, or even a way to reflect on your own development.

Motivation and team fit

Explores candidates' aspirations, alignment with and contribution to team values, and ability to thrive in a dynamic setting.

1. Why are you looking to make a job change?
2. Before this interview, what did you learn about our CDO organization that surprised or intrigued you? What questions did that raise for you?
3. What drew you to IBM in the first place and then to this specific role on our team? What feels exciting or meaningful about the work we do?
4. What kind of team culture brings out your best work? How do you contribute to building that kind of environment?

Collaboration and communication

Explores how candidates work with others across disciplines, time zones, and organizational boundaries. Focuses on teamwork, communication habits, and conflict resolution.

5. What tools or habits do you rely on to stay aligned with global teams when real-time collaboration isn't possible? Can you share a specific example?
6. How do you make it easy for others—especially remote teammates—to give you what you need to move forward in your work? Can you share a technique or example?
7. Tell me about a time where you had to lead without formal authority. How did you get others to follow your direction or support your ideas?
8. Tell me about a time when a someone you needed to collaborate with was disengaged or unresponsive. How did you get them to participate?

Growth and learning

Assesses adaptability, self-awareness, and how candidates respond to feedback and challenges. Focuses on continuous improvement and learning agility.

9. Describe a situation where you had to learn something completely new in a short amount of time. How did you approach the learning curve?
10. Can you share an example of when you realized your current skill set wasn't enough for a challenge you faced? What did you do to close the gap?
11. Tell me about a time when feedback made you uncomfortable or defensive. How did you move past that reaction and turn it into something constructive?
12. What's something about our team or this role that feels like a stretch for you? What kind of support would help you succeed in that area?

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Problem solving and decision making

Evaluates how candidates handle ambiguity, make decisions under pressure, and navigate complex situations.

13. Describe a time you had to deliver something with really tight deadlines. How did determine where to start? How did you decide what was “good enough?”
14. Tell me about a time when the problem you ultimately addressed turned out to be different than what was originally framed. How did you uncover the real issue?
15. Describe a situation where you had to make a decision or take action without clear guidance. How did you navigate the ambiguity, and what did you learn?
16. Have you ever worked on a project where the constraints felt unreasonable or constantly shifting? How did you stay focused and productive?

Impact and influence

Looks at how candidates persuade others, gain alignment, and communicate the value of their work.

17. Tell me about a time when your design work directly contributed to a measurable business result. What was the need, and how did your work make a difference?
18. Can you share an example of a project where you connected user needs to business goals—and saw tangible results? What did you learn from that experience?
19. Describe a situation when you had to advocate for a design or strategy that others didn’t initially support or understand. How did you win them over?
20. Have you ever had to explain the business impact of your work to a non-designer? What did you say, and how did you make it resonate?

Creativity and process

Explores design thinking, creativity, and how candidates approach the full design lifecycle.

21. What’s the most unconventional solution you’ve ever proposed or implemented? How did you convince others to try it, and what was the result?
22. Think of a project where you had to make trade-offs between your ideal design and real-world constraints. How did you decide what was worth compromising? Is there anything you’ll never compromise on?
23. Please share your screen and load your portfolio website. How did you get feedback on your site and incorporate that into what I’m seeing now?
24. Please share your screen, load your portfolio, and let’s take a look at your _____ project together. *[Ask about a specific project’s intention, process, deliverables, challenges, or outcomes.]*

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